

RESEARCH ARTICLE



The Old World and the Intellectual History of American Slavery

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ABSTRACT

A series of recent books examining the intellectual history of American slavery points to the continuing influence of European ideas not only on the practice of enslavement and subsequent justifications of it, but also on the post-Civil War historiography of the phenomenon. In *The Intellectual Origins of American Slavery*, John Harpham points to the importance of Roman law categories and arguments in justifying the initial practice by which certain individuals – not for reasons of their race, but because they had been made captive in war or as punishment for crimes – found themselves enslaved. The presumption of Roman law favoured freedom, but explained why, in certain instances, this could be lost. Keidrick Roy in *American Dark Age* points to a fascination in the antebellum South with Europe's medieval past, whereby comparisons of the plantation system with feudalism and the paternalism it supposedly engendered served to soften perceptions of the exploitative character of slavery. Scott Spillman in *Making Sense of Slavery* reviews the intellectual history of American slavery between the mid-eighteenth century and the present, first as a contested presence in American life and then after the Civil War as the subject of historical investigation.

KEYWORDS

Slavery; Roman law; racial feudalism

Works reviewed

John Samuel Harpham, *The Intellectual Origins of American Slavery: English Ideas in the Early Modern Atlantic World*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2025.

Keidrick Roy, *American Dark Age: Racial Feudalism and the Rise of Black Liberalism*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2024.

Scott Spillman, *Making Sense of Slavery: America's Long Reckoning from the Founding Era to Today*. New York: Basic Books, 2025.

The historiography of American slavery was traditionally confined to a regional cul-de-sac. The 'peculiar institution' was reckoned a distinctively Southern phenomenon, and as such a crucial part of a sectional narrative that diverged anomalously – until it ran out

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of road – from the mainstream history of American liberty. From the post-War era onwards that kind of pigeonholing has come – as a result of several waves of revision and reinterpretation – to seem less and less persuasive. Most historians now acknowledge the centrality of slavery to the American experience as a whole, something that, while broadly accepted within the academy (apart from some cavils about the grander claims of the 1619 Project), does not, of course, enjoy the same uncontroversial purchase with the general public, at least in certain quarters. Moreover, it is also generally accepted among historians that a wider lens than a purely national one is required to understand slavery, which is now studied in an Atlantic world context that encompasses other parts of the Western hemisphere, the Caribbean in particular, as well as Europe and Africa. The 1960s witnessed a turn away from a reductively materialist account of slavery as a mode of production. This interpretation meshed comfortably with the recognition that it was cultural factors, not economic limitations intrinsic to the slave system, that brought about its demise, and in turn it highlighted the interconnectedness of evangelical anti-slavery campaigning on both sides of the Atlantic. More recently, the new history of capitalism has presented slavery within a global frame of exploitation, commodification and intercontinental trading networks, which has restored a broadly materialist interpretation of the topic to its former dominance. However, its sway has not gone unchallenged. As we shall see, a further wave of intellectual history is bringing into sharper focus the specific influences of the Old World – Europe especially – on the culture of the New, whether during the initial stages of early modern enslavement in the seventeenth century, as a lingering presence into the nineteenth, or as a crucial external factor which, to a surprising degree, shaped multiple American attempts to make sense of slavery between the eighteenth and twentieth centuries.

John Samuel Harpham's first book, *The Intellectual Origins of American Slavery*, is a remarkable debut.¹ It provides a stunning and original set of answers to the most difficult question with which slavery presents us. If we today experience a universal revulsion at practices of enslavement, why did so many preceding generations between the seventeenth and nineteenth centuries acquiesce so easily in something so abominable? To all intents and purposes the practice seemed to have been accepted with a casualness that verged on the enigmatic and without any apparent need in its earliest phase for a defence of the indefensible. What, Harpham wonders, was the logic by which early modern Englishmen justified their participation in a monstrous set of behaviours? And why did it occasion at first no apparent qualms or debate, outright opposition to the transatlantic slave trade and the slave plantations of the Western hemisphere only coming later, from the mid-eighteenth century onwards?

Harpham appreciates why American slavery has largely been understood as a straightforward matter of material interests and opportunities. After all, contemporary traders and planters did not stir themselves to offer moral justifications of their behaviours. Was that simply a reflection of the wholly materialist motivations of self-interested philistines? Or was it, Harpham suggests, because their actions conformed to a broadly accepted set of assumptions that did not call for explicit explanation or extenuation? Perhaps, slavery was not only profitable, but, by contemporary lights, also a legitimate enterprise. But how could this be so?

Harpham focuses on prevailing patterns of rationalizing slavery, with a central focus on what were then perceived as uncontroversially legitimate modes of enslavement. If Harpham's answer is surprising so are the chronological contours and geographical focus of his book, for his primary concern is the century before the full emergence of English colonial slavery and its centre of gravity is Africa rather than America, which was paradoxically 'peripheral to the context of ideas in which American slavery began.'² Indeed, ideas about slavery, he claims, did not emerge in tandem with contemporary practices, but earlier and in a more abstract way as part of a tradition of thinking about the laws of nature and nations. By reaching back into the prehistory of colonial slavery, Harpham is able to offer a persuasive challenge to an entire canon of received assumptions about its underpinnings. Slavery was not initially justified on the basis of Aristotelian notions that some people were by nature inherently fitted to be slaves. Nor did slavery arise from a binary mode of classification that contrasted European civility with African savagery, or from crudely racist prejudices that black Africans were the inferiors of white Europeans. None of these assumptions are warranted. By immersing himself in the literatures of jurisprudence and African voyaging in the era immediately prior to the rise of slaveholding in England's American colonies, Harpham rediscovers unfamiliar ways of looking at the world which call into question our deeply-lodged presuppositions about the early modern Anglo-African encounter.

Harpham foregrounds distinctions that lurked in the nooks and crannies of David Brion Davis's classic work *The Problem of Slavery in American Culture* (1966).³ Davis was aware of differences between the Aristotelian proposition that slavery was natural and the Roman law view that slavery belonged not to the *ius naturale*, but rather to the *ius gentium*. However, Brion Davis – notwithstanding the subtle richness of his discussions – had underplayed such differences in his broader argument, emphasising instead the problematic legacy on the question of slavery that antiquity as a whole – biblical, Greek and Roman – had bequeathed the early modern period. Harpham, by contrast, brings into relief the distinctions that Brion Davis had touched on only in passing. He stresses that in classical antiquity there were two distinct and baldly contrasting traditions, the familiar one derived from Aristotle but also another from Roman law; and in early modern England, Harpham argues, the latter was clearly dominant. Notwithstanding English pride in the distinctiveness of its common law, we should not discount the early modern reception in England of the Roman law, and the imprint of civilians on its jurisprudence, including the likes of John Cowell or Alberico Gentili, a Protestant exile from Italy.

Early modern understandings of slavery were derived in large part from the *Corpus Iuris Civilis* compiled under the auspices of the Emperor Justinian in the sixth century AD. Contrary to the Aristotelian claim that there were slaves in nature, Roman law started from the assumption that all men were free. However, there were circumstances in which a free person could lose his status, most commonly by being taken captive in war. Early modern contemporaries thought about slaves as persons rather than slavery as a system. There were reasons why individuals might through force of circumstance find themselves enslaved. Roman law explained the enslavement of some in the context of the natural freedom of humankind as a whole. According to the *Institutes* of Justinian slavery was 'contrary to the law of nature', by which 'all men were initially born free'.⁴

The English prided themselves on their liberty and, moreover, sharply contrasted their values from those of contemporary Iberians. In Richard Jobson's narrative of his recent voyage to Gambia, published in 1623, he recounted how he had met an African trader down river who had offered him three women as slaves. On declining the offer, Jobson was told that such slaves were much desired by Portuguese traders. He responded that the Portuguese were 'another kinde of people different from us'.⁵ Harpham thinks that an overemphasis on the fluidity of the early modern Atlantic world has obscured contrasts between fullthroated Iberian participation in the slave trade and the reticence and discrimination that marked early English involvement before the 1630s. Some of the first African slaves to arrive in England's New World territories were accidental acquisitions from raids on Spanish or Portuguese ships. This was the case with the first African slaves in Bermuda and Virginia. The English were not at first directly involved in what at least some English authors referred to as this 'unnatural trade'. Nevertheless, they were drawn into it and came to forget these earlier scruples. But what did not change during the course of the seventeenth century, Harpham argues, was the enduring neo-Roman framework of English ideas about slavery.

Harpham's work provides a major challenge to the standard interpretation of early modern English attitudes to Africans found in Winthrop Jordan's classic work *White over Black* (1968).⁶ Harpham explores contemporary English discussions of racial complexion and does not discern any clear linkage between blackness and inferiority. Differences of complexion, he contends, were tackled as an intellectual-cum-theological problem, but were not understood primarily in terms of racial or civilizational hierarchies. In the seventeenth century blackness had not yet acquired what later generations were to regard as an indelible association with slavery. As Harpham notices (and as I have also argued), the monogenist theological imperative operating in early modern culture did not encourage the delineation and emphasizing of difference, but rather the very opposite: a quest for the underlying resemblances which displayed the essential unity – within so much diversity – of a single human race.⁷

Indeed, early moderns did not depict Africa as a dark continent of brutality and savagery; that image was coined much later in the nineteenth century during an era of unrestrained racialism. Early modern voyagers to Africa did not present it as an alien world, but rather as one whose social contours bore a marked similarity to prevailing European norms. The dominant picture of Africa in early modern accounts, Harpham notes, was a scene of settled government and civil life, though one – as in Europe – which witnessed fierce interstate conflicts. And it was here in warfare that early modern Englishmen detected the sources of African slavery. Defeated combatants found themselves enslaved – a situation which was all too easily aligned with the tenets of Roman law.

Whereas in classical texts Africa had been depicted as an exotic place, early modern English traders who visited Africa noticed rather the similarities between Africa and Europe: the existence of states, the practice of commerce, the flourishing of civil life. Moreover, what stood out to contemporary observers was not any single essence of African life and culture, but the continent's rich plurality of nations, customs and institutions. Ironically, Harpham notes, 'slaves in Africa circulated almost entirely among the peoples who appeared to authors from Europe most complex, most civil, and most similar to themselves'.⁸ The main sources of enslavement were judicial punishment for crime and being taken captive in war. Hence, it was the high level of civilization attained

by Africans – not any supposed savagery – which explained the provenance of enslavement.

Harpham draws on a vast range of sources – legal treatises, theological works, philosophical tracts, travellers' accounts, works of fiction and maps; and it is his command of the materials which supplies the buoyant, confident authority of this radically subversive thesis. For much of the seventeenth century English commentators, such as the dissenting theologian Richard Baxter in his *Christian Directory* (1673), were generally unconcerned about the lawful routes into slavery – which were traditional and widely accepted – yet were appalled to learn that some slaves had entered the trade by illegitimate means. Harpham re-reads canonical texts in the light of the prevailing patterns he discerns. Notwithstanding its depiction of a slave revolt, Aphra Behn's *Oroonoko* (1688), was, Harpham insists, not a straightforward emancipation novel. Behn, he notices, distinguishes between legitimate and illegitimate slavery, between those enslaved because 'vanquish'd ... nobly' in war or 'won ... in honourable battel' – something which 'wou'd not anger a noble heart' – and those obtained by unsavoury means which were not endorsed by the civil law or the law of nations.⁹ It was Roman law insights not racial prejudice which provided initial justification for the Atlantic commerce in enslaved people from Africa.

Harpham's story ends in the late seventeenth century when Englishmen in the New World lost the traditional scruples which had attended early seventeenth-century encounters with African enslavement. Those earlier limits had been first fudged and then forgotten. No longer was there the same concern to establish that the initial enslavement of each individual conformed to the legitimate routes into servitude set out in Roman law. Harpham's subtle account of transitions in racial thinking stands at a considerable remove from Jordan's more static thesis about a deep-rooted and largely unchanging picture of anti-Black prejudice. New rationalizations emerged from the late seventeenth century in the wake of what was now a *fait accompli*. Notably, it was in the Caribbean – not in Africa, where traditional concerns about the circumstances of enslavement persisted – that new pretexts appeared. The shift in the late seventeenth century was from particular instances to broad collective generalisations, from explanations of how certain free individuals had come to be enslaved to the rationale for why an entire category of people was enslaved. As a result, Aristotelian notions began to resurface, albeit at first still at the margins of English discourse. Moreover, the new situation would also require a corresponding shift in attitudes towards Africa and its peoples. The assumptions we have inherited about slavery and its supposed justification derive, Harpham argues, from a later era.

Whereas Harpham's England is a post-feudal society, one whose self-image in the sixteenth century as a realm of freedom followed the decline of villeinage, Keidrick Roy highlights the reinvention of feudal ideas in the nineteenth century as a redescription of plantation slavery. Primarily, this strain of euphemism offered a means by which proponents of slavery were able to soften its harsher edges. However, as Roy demonstrates in *American Dark Age*,¹⁰ matters were far from straightforward. With considerable nuance and sophistication Roy points to the multiple discourses which emerged around the concept of feudalism in American life between the late eighteenth and late nineteenth centuries: romanticized medievalism, a white anti-feudalism with its roots in the Enlightenment, arguments for natural aristocracy, a hybridised racial feudalism, and a Black

liberalism, informed by anti-feudalism, which rejected as un-American the Southern aristocracy of the skin. Moreover, Roy is alert to the ways in which these positions sometimes overlapped and the tensions which resulted. Such contradictions were most obvious in the case of Thomas Jefferson, who campaigned for the abolition of entail in Virginia, but was also drawn to ideas of natural aristocracy. The medieval past – as Roy recognises – was itself multi-layered and pregnant with a range of meanings. Jefferson, most notably, championed the ultimate Anglo-Saxon origins of American freedoms, but espoused a radical anti-Normanism which blamed the feudal perversion of English laws and institutions on the invasion of England by William the Conqueror in 1066. This was a standard element in English radical politics from the mid-seventeenth century, and Jefferson adopted it wholesale.

The reception – or, more pointedly, absence – of feudalism in America has exercised historians since the influential arguments of Louis Hartz's *The Liberal Tradition in America* (1955).¹¹ Hartz argued that a Lockean liberalism flourished in America precisely because feudalism had not been transplanted from Europe to the American colonies. The only exception to this in Hartz's thesis, as Roy notes, was the insubstantial existence of a 'hollow'¹² feudal ideal in the South. However, an important essay by Rowland Berthoff and John Murrin pointed to a feudal revival in the eighteenth-century colonies;¹³ and, ironically, various scholars have drawn attention to Locke's own contribution during the 1670s to projected neo-feudal arrangements for governance and landholding in the Carolinas.¹⁴ Issues such as primogeniture and entail were, it is now recognised, an issue in the newly independent States of the late 1770s.¹⁵

Less controversially, the influence of Sir Walter Scott's Waverley novels – *Ivanhoe* (1820) especially – on the self-image of the antebellum South has long been a staple of cultural and literary history. Roy too shows how Scott's fictions 'entranced' the South, which saw 'its reflection in the looking glass of the medieval world'.¹⁶ However, his analysis extends far beyond the cult of Scott. He is attentive to the way in which feudal reveries, racial identities and an anti-feudalist backlash premised on the liberal promise of American independence were interwoven – variously and in different combinations – in the ideologies of Black as well as white Americans. Moreover, the same rhetoric about feudalism and aristocracy could be found on both sides of the slavery debate, whether in George Fitzhugh's anti-capitalist sociology or in the abolitionist newspaper, *The Liberator*. Medieval Europe occupied a central place in the antebellum imagination. Social stratification, proponents of slavery contended, was natural, inevitable, and potentially benign. Champions of the Southern way of life emphasised its paternalism, the mutual obligations of masters and slaves, and its blended ideals of 'racial honor' and 'racial fealty'.¹⁷ Feudalism, in Roy's description, 'cloaked'¹⁸ the horrors of slavery. 'Treachery sentiments' about a medieval past and its graceful continuation in the South served to palliate the grimmer realities of economic exploitation.¹⁹ On the other hand, Black writers regarded such relics of Old World feudalism as the negation of the life, liberty and pursuit of happiness enshrined in the Declaration of Independence. If the Revolution marked America's separation from the Old World, then Black liberals called for the fulfilment of a process begun in 1776 but only half-finished. According to the Black abolitionist Frederick Douglass, the shortcomings of a 'Constitution made in the shadow of slavery and of monarchy' were all too blatant.²⁰ Black liberals perceived the Revolution not as a rupture, but as a dismal continuation of European forms which blighted the

promise of American freedom. In addition, Black Protestants perceived Popish tints in the medieval-like oppressions of the Southern plantation system, which belonged not to an American liberal present, but to a Romish dark age. Racial feudalism, according to Roy, offered Black liberals 'a photographic negative against which to develop novel expressions of liberalism'.²¹

Neo-medieval symbolism outlived the Civil War and the demise of the Old South. The robes and rituals of the Ku Klux Klan harked back to an imagined medieval past. Meanwhile, the Black sociologist and historian W.E.B. Du Bois, reflecting on the origins of New World slavery in 1915, argued that the early slave codes had signified 'an attempt to reestablish in America the waning feudalism of Europe'.²² But what had really changed since the Civil War? Black people remained essentially 'servants and serfs', and the stigma attached to a lingering and un-American Old World 'mediaevalism' persisted.²³

Europe is very far from being the primary concern of Scott Spillman's fascinating exploration of the intellectual history of American slavery over the course of its history and long post-Civil War aftermath.²⁴ Yet it is astonishing how often Spillman identifies European influences at work in American intellectual life, whether as a result of the direct adoption of European ideas, or via the arrival of European scholars in the United States, or from the sojourns of American intellectuals at German universities. Europe is less an offstage whisper than an obtrusive and unnerving presence in Spillman's ostensibly American story.

Spillman locates the beginning of his story in the mid-eighteenth century, for it was only then that, because of 'a fundamental shift in human moral perception', slavery came into focus as an intellectual problem. This remarkable change in outlook he attributes to two very distinct cultural developments, namely the emergence within the Enlightenment of an ethic of universal benevolence and within a radical strain of Protestant Christianity a new emphasis on human equality and brotherhood. This latter development was most evident among the Quakers, and here the central figure was Anthony Benezet, born of Huguenot stock in France, but whose conversion to Quakerism in Philadelphia led him to view slavery as an enormity and to campaign against it. Anti-slavery sentiments percolated beyond Quakerism into various branches of evangelical Protestantism, and gave rise over the following decades to transatlantic networks of abolitionist activism. The legacy of the Enlightenment was not quite so straightforward. Montesquieu, the most cited author in late eighteenth-century America, had argued that while humans were by nature free, in certain regions a hot, sultry climate so enervated men that only the imposition of slavery and strict forms of labour discipline kept them at work.

Notwithstanding the dominant presence of the classics in colonial college curricula, ancient Greco-Roman slavery had, ironically, not been a central preoccupation of early American intellectual life. This was because the primary pedagogical concern was with the acquisition of ancient languages, which left the study of ancient society as something of an afterthought. Nevertheless, the mid eighteenth-century debate within the Scottish Enlightenment over the demographic consequences of ancient slavery between David Hume and Robert Wallace began to redress the anomaly. But it was German scholarship in the early nineteenth century which brought ancient economic life firmly onto the agenda of classical scholarship. The most celebrated of nineteenth-century American

historians, George Bancroft, studied at Berlin under August Böckh, who, under the influence of Barthold Niebuhr, had made economic life and slavery a central part of ancient history. In a public lecture of 1834 on 'Slavery in Rome', which was published in the *North American Review*, Bancroft argued that the introduction of slavery had reduced the hardy, upright farmers of ancient Rome into a benighted urban mob, thereby initiating a vicious circle of constitutional decline which transformed democracy into first aristocracy and then eventually despotism. Free labour, Bancroft contended, was a vital prop of republican liberty. But others drew a different lesson from classical antiquity. Thomas Dew, a professor at William and Mary, argued that slavery was the foundation of ancient civilizations and throughout history had served as an instrument of progress. George Frederick Holmes, born in Georgetown in the British colonial possession of Guyana and then brought up in England, moved as a young adult to Virginia where in his writings he drew on Aristotle – described by Spillman as 'a sort of house philosopher for the South' – to argue that all societies, ancient and modern, rested on two broad classes, 'the dependent and those on whom they depend'.²⁵ According to Holmes, slavery provided a means of codifying the relations between the haves and the have nots, one which was freer of abuses than the randomness of treatment intrinsic to systems of free labour.

The insights of British political economy were redeployed in American arguments about the pros and cons and future prospects of the slave system. Thomas Cooper, an emigrant from England who became a professor at South Carolina College, drew on the arguments of Adam Smith that because slaves had less incentive to work hard than free men, slavery was less efficient and ultimately – all superficial appearances to the contrary notwithstanding – more expensive than waged labour. However, Cooper owned slaves himself and also had to confront the awkward difficulty that the prosperous Southern planter class was thriving despite its reliance on slave labour. He concluded that slave labour was indeed less efficient than its waged equivalent, but in the unpropitious conditions of the American South some form of compulsion was necessary were cultivation to take place at all. George Tucker, a Virginia congressman, utilised the demographic theories of Thomas Malthus to argue that as population spread across the uncultivated regions of the United States, human labour would decline in value and eventually undercut slavery, which would perish, as it had in Europe, from a reduced demand – and consequently lowered costs – for labour relative to the labour pool. Tucker favoured the expansion of slavery into the West, but foreseeing its ultimate demise, reckoned that the real long-term question was the relative density of the free Black population at the point when slavery became unviable: far better then, he contended, a Black populace dispersed thinly across the country than clumped together as a majority in one region. In a similar fashion, the English economist of colonization, Edward Gibbon Wakefield, favoured restricting the availability of land in America and the importation of free labour from Europe as a means of undermining the economic rationale for slavery. Intriguingly, British political economy seemed to point forward to the peaceful euthanasia of American slavery, a system which would gradually expire when America no longer had, in the words of Wakefield, a 'superabundance of land in proportion to people'.²⁶

Of course, that's not how matters transpired. In the wake of the Civil War, Spillman notes, debates about slavery continued, and indeed raised new questions about race relations and social equality that now had to be confronted directly rather than treated

indirectly, as formerly, via the primary issue of the slave system. Moreover, slavery as such was now in the past, and henceforth historiography necessarily became the central arena of debate on such matters. Indeed, the German historian Hermann Eduard von Holst published a multi-volume history of the United States in 1873, immediately translated for the American market in 1876, which saw slavery as the central preoccupying feature of American history. Nevertheless, a couple of historiographical trends which soon followed served to relegate slavery to a regional backwater of the nation's history. In particular, Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier thesis and the cynical interests-based revisionism of Charles Beard, in neither of which slavery loomed large, tended to marginalise the topic. Yet, as Spillman notes, slavery had until recently been not only a national issue, but also a universal one, that classically-informed scholars saw as a continuous and important theme in the historical record from classical antiquity to the present.

Although slavery became for many decades a predominantly Southern subject, European influences continued to shape its development. The Southern historian-cum-apologist William Dunning spent a year in Germany, and it was during a spell at the University of Berlin that the Black polymath Du Bois was exposed to the historical economics of Gustav von Schmoller. The reintegration of slavery as a central focus of American historiography came in the aftermath of World War II, and was to some degree shaped by the legacy of the War. The Swedish sociologist Gunnar Myrdal, who had come to the United States in 1938, envisaged his book *An American Dilemma* (1944) as a contribution to the War effort: after all, if America was to be the leader of the democracies, how could it reconcile a dismal record of military segregation in the forces of freedom and more generalised anti-Black prejudices with ideals of freedom, justice and human dignity. Myrdal recognised at the core of America's dilemma the enduring legacy of slavery. More directly, the historians Stanley Elkins and Eric McKittrick drew on the distorting mental effects of concentration camp life explored by the émigré Austrian Jewish psychologist Bruno Bettelheim as they attempted to reconstruct the inner life of the enslaved.

In the last half-century nobody did more to recapture the culture of the enslaved and, equally, the mentality of the master class that ruled over them than Eugene Genovese, whose Marxist approach – and to some degree his later post-Marxist conversion to a sympathetically reactionary neo-Confederate stance²⁷ – owed much to the theory of hegemony advanced by the Italian Marxist Antonio Gramsci. Marx is a strangely recessive presence in Spillman's book. So many of the figures who reinvigorated the post-War historiography of American slavery had some exposure to Marxism – even if they did not join the Communist Party itself – including its presiding figures, C. Vann Woodward and Kenneth Stampp. Moses Finley – born Moses Finkelstein – was a victim of the anti-Communist paranoia of the 1950s and was dismissed from Rutgers University for taking the Fifth Amendment when asked by the authorities about his involvement in Communist activities. A distinguished classicist, Finley was able to relocate to the University of Cambridge, where he not only established himself as a major authority on the economic history of classical antiquity, but as Spillman notes, made a crucial distinction in historical sociology between 'slave societies' – such as Greece, Rome and the antebellum South – and what were merely 'societies with slaves'.²⁸ Finley's *Ancient Slavery and Modern Ideology* (1980) attempted to explain the more general transformation of one type of slave-holding society into the other.²⁹ In the work of Finley and Brion Davis one sees the

restoration of slavery as a central problem in the general history of civilization, and in some measure a full-circle return to the broader preoccupations of early nineteenth-century intellectual life.

All three books under review remind us that little do they know of American slavery's intellectual history who know little of European history. American intellectual life was far from a world unto itself, even in the antebellum South, as we recall from the wealth of interconnections tapped in Michael O'Brien's *Conjectures of Order: Intellectual Life and the American South* (2004).³⁰ Harpham informs the reader that his own book is the first in a projected trilogy. It seems clear that for the foreseeable future we can anticipate the continued reengagement of American slavery with the history of European ideas.

Notes

1. Harpham, *Intellectual Origins of American Slavery*.
2. *Ibid.*, 5.
3. Davis, *Problem of Slavery*, 100, 121.
4. Harpham, *Intellectual Origins of American Slavery*, 27.
5. *Ibid.*, 88.
6. Jordan, *White over Black*.
7. Colin Kidd, *Forging of Races*.
8. Harpham, *Intellectual Origins of American Slavery*, 143.
9. *Ibid.*, 178.
10. Roy, *American Dark Age*.
11. Hartz, *Liberal Tradition in America*.
12. Roy, *American Dark Age*, 25.
13. Berthoff and Murrin, "Feudalism, Communalism and the Yeoman Freeholder".
14. Armitage, "Locke, Carolina and the *Two Treatises*".
15. Brewer, "Entailing Aristocracy".
16. Roy, *American Dark Age*, 79.
17. *Ibid.*, 9, 102, 111, 132.
18. *Ibid.*, xi.
19. *Ibid.*, 9.
20. *Ibid.*, 5.
21. *Ibid.*, 5–6.
22. *Ibid.*, 98.
23. *Ibid.*, 233.
24. Spillman, *Making Sense of Slavery*.
25. *Ibid.*, 77.
26. *Ibid.*, 57.
27. Genovese and Fox-Genovese, *Mind of the Master Class*.
28. Spillman, *Making Sense of Slavery*, 309.
29. Finley, *Ancient Slavery and Modern Ideology*.
30. O'Brien, *Conjectures of Order*.

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